

The city-states weren't all getting along when the baby, who was named Leonardo, came into the world. Milan and Venice were fighting, but luckily the war wasn't in Anchio. So Leonardo, surrounded by peaceful vineyards and olive groves, was happily unaware of it.



Still, the life that lay before him was going to be challenging. His father was Ser Piero da Vinci. The title "Ser" meant that Piero was a respected gentleman. Ser Piero was a notary, a public official who helped people create legal documents and contracts. Leonardo's mother, Caterina, had no such status. She was a peasant. This wouldn't have mattered if she and Ser Piero were married, but they weren't. Therefore, any child they had was illegitimate and not protected by the law. That meant Ser Piero could have simply ignored the boy, which would have made life very difficult for Leonardo.

